Flattening the Discrepancy: Gravity-Consistent Model for a Disk-Shaped Earth

Evan Widloski
evan_bovik@widloski.com

Electrical and Computer Engineering
University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

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1. Abstract

The flat Earth model, in which the Earth is a disk or cylindrical slab of uniform density, predicts a gravitational field that varies significantly with distance from the center — inconsistent with ground-based gravimetry measurements showing deviations of less than 0.07% from standard 1g acceleration. In this work, we investigate whether relaxing the uniform-density assumption of the cylindrical slab model can reconcile the flat Earth hypothesis with observed gravimetric data. We introduce the Axially-Symmetric Slab (ASS) parameterization, which allows the slab thickness to vary as a function of radius, and pose the problem of finding a density profile that minimizes gravity field non-uniformity over the disk surface. Using a differentiable forward model and numerical optimization, we identify slab profiles that produce gravity field deviations within gravimetric survey limits. Our results demonstrate that a non-uniform flat Earth mass distribution can produce a gravitational field indistinguishable from measurements, offering a quantitative response to one of the primary physical objections to the flat Earth model.

2. Introduction

For nearly 200 years a fierce debate over the true nature of our world has been ongoing between those who believe the Earth is shaped like a sphere/geoid (known as "sphericists"/"globe-heads") and those who think the earth is a flat disk or slab ("flat-earthers"/"flerfs").

One such point of contention between these two groups is the issue of the uniformity of gravity. While a sphere of constant density naturally has consistent, nadir-pointing gravitational acceleration over its surface, on a disk a person walking from the center towards the edge will experience increasing gravitational resistance as if they are walking uphill, shown in Figure 1. Extensive gravimetric surveys that show local deviations from standard 1 g acceleration of no more than 0.1% (ε=0.001) [1], as in Figure 2.

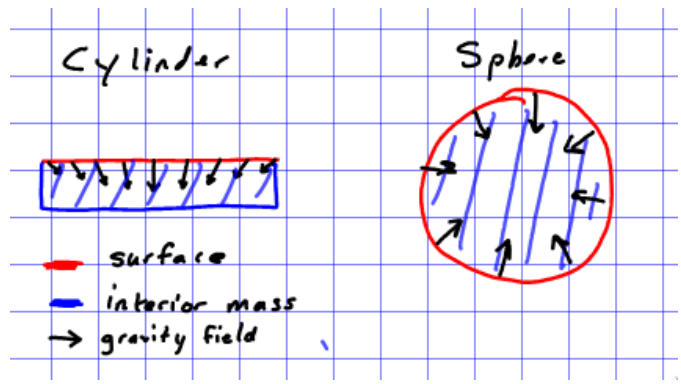

Figure 1: Gravity field of a cylindrical flat Earth and a spherical Earth

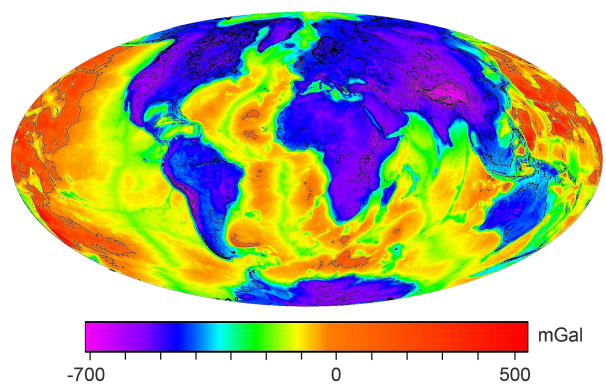

Figure 2: Gravity anomaly map from GOCE spacecraft

While not all flat-earthers believe in a gravitational force (e.g. preferring the view that the Earth is accelerating upwards at 1 g), for the sake of argument we assume that the classical model of gravity holds. We also do not address theories adjacent to flat Earth, such as hollow Earth (concave or convex), infinite-plane Earth, toroidal Earth, Klein-bottle Earth or cosmic turtles.

In this manuscript, we show that by relaxing the cylindrical slab assumption slightly, it is possible to achieve a gravity field uniformity consistent with gravimetric measurements over the Earth's surface. We provide some examples found numerically[1].

[1]Code available at https://github.com/evidlo/sigbovik2026

We hope that by constructing these examples of mass distributions, we can put to rest this specific counter-argument and better understand our (flat) world.

In the following sections, we define the physics that relate mass distribution to gravity vector field at the Earth's surface, propose two extensions to the simple cylindrical slab model of Earth and approaches to numerically evaluate them, and finally show a numerical analysis of these models.

3. Physics Forward Model and Problem Statement

In this section we establish the physics of the flat Earth mass distribution problem, then write out a constrained optimization problem that finds a mass distribution meeting the gravity uniformity requirement.

3.1. Arbitrary Mass Distribution

Let D be an origin-centered disk with diameter 1 in the $z = 0$ plane and $\rho : \mathbb{R}^3 \to \mathbb{R}$ be a non-negative scalar field representing mass density that is 0 for $z > 0$.

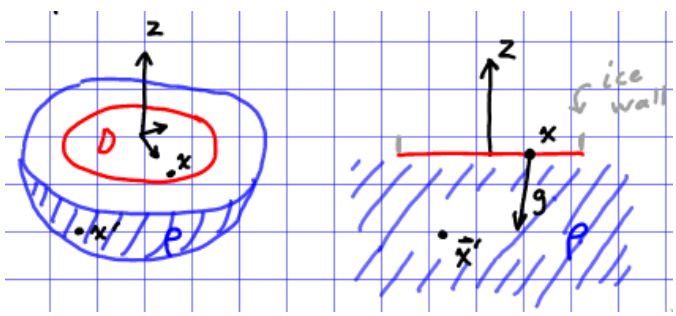

Figure 3: Surface of Earth disk D (in red) in $z = 0$ plane with mass distribution ρ below. x is an observation point on the disk and x' is an arbitrary source point that contributes to the gravity field at x

We can write the gravitational field $g : \mathbb{R}^3 \to \mathbb{R}^3$ at any point x on the surface D as

$$g(x) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^3} G \frac{\rho(x')}{|x - x'|^2} \cdot \frac{x - x'}{|x - x'|} \, \mathrm{d}x' \tag{1}$$

Then the problem of finding a mass distribution which produces a uniform downward acceleration $g_0 = (0, 0, -9.81)$ m/s^2 may be stated

$$\begin{gathered} \text{Find a density distribution } \rho(x') \\ \text{which satisfies } |g(x) - g_0| = 0 \text{ for all } x \in D \end{gathered} \tag{2}$$

By the identity theorem of harmonic functions, the requirement that $|g(x) - g_0| = 0$ on the disk D would require infinite mass in $\rho(x')$ (e.g. an infinite uniform slab). However, relaxing the problem to allow deviations in an ε-ball around g_0 permits solutions with finite mass. Indeed, gravimetry measurements show variations in local gravity field on the surface of the Earth up to ~0.1% (ε=0.001) [1].

The problem, restated, is

$$\begin{gathered} \text{Find a density distribution } \rho(x') \\ \text{which satisfies } |g(x) - g_0| \leq \varepsilon |g_0| \text{ for all } x \in D \end{gathered} \tag{3}$$

3.2. Axially-Symmetric Mass Distribution

Assuming that ρ is axially-symmetric around the z-axis, we can write x and x' in cylindrical coordinates without loss of generality as

$$x = \begin{pmatrix} r \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \text{ and } x' = \begin{pmatrix} r' \cos\theta' \\ r' \sin\theta' \\ z' \end{pmatrix} \tag{4}$$

and reparameterize the density $\rho(x') \to \rho(r', z')$

Then the gravity field in cylindrical coordinates is

$$\begin{aligned} g_r(r) &= \int_0^{2\pi} \int_0^{\infty} \int_{-\infty}^{0} \frac{\rho(r', z') \cdot (r - r' \cos\theta')}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr' \cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}} \, \mathrm{d}z' r' \, \mathrm{d}r' \, \mathrm{d}\theta' \\ g_\theta(r) &= 0 \\ g_z(r) &= \int_0^{2\pi} \int_0^{\infty} \int_{-\infty}^{0} \frac{\rho(r', z') \cdot -z'}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr' \cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}} \, \mathrm{d}z' r' \, \mathrm{d}r' \, \mathrm{d}\theta' \end{aligned} \tag{5}$$

and the angular component g_θ is 0 due to symmetry (see Section 8.2).

4. Mass Distribution Models

4.1. Overhang Cylinder Parameterization

4.2. Axially-Symmetric Slab Parameterization

In this section we define the Axially-Symmetric Slab (ASS) parameterization, a generalization of the overhang cylinder model which allows the height of the cylinder to vary with radius. In this case, the mass distribution is

$$\rho(r', z') := \begin{cases} 1 \text{ if } 0 \leq z' \leq -b(r') \\ 0 \text{ else} \end{cases} \tag{6}$$

where $-b(r')$ is a 1D profile that lower-bounds the slab when revolved.

5. Results

6. Conclusion and Future Work

In this work we discuss the issue of gravity uniformity in the flat model of the Earth. By allowing small deviations in the gravity field from a nadir pointing unit-vector, we show that an axially-symmetric slab of mass can produce a field that is consistent with ground-based gravimetry measurements (FIXME: cite).

7. Acknowledgements

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8. Appendix

8.1. Symbols

- $x \in \mathbb{R}^3$ - observation point on surface of disk
- $x' \in \mathbb{R}^3$ - source point below surface of disk
- $g(x) \in \mathbb{R}^3$ - gravity vector field at a point x on surface of disk

8.2. ASS Gravity Field

First write the gravity field at an observation point x on the disk surface due to a point source of mass x' beneath the disk.

$$g(x, x') = G\frac{\rho(x')}{|x - x'|} \cdot \frac{x - x'}{|x - x'|} = \rho(x') \cdot \frac{x - x'}{|x - x'|^3} \tag{7}$$

Integrating over all $x' \in \mathbb{R}$

$$g(x) = \int_{\mathbb{R}^3} g(x, x')\,\mathrm{d}x' = \int_{\mathbb{R}^3} \rho(x') \cdot \frac{x - x'}{|x - x'|^3}\,\mathrm{d}x' \tag{8}$$

Due to the assumed axial symmetry of ρ, without loss of generality we can write in cylindrical coordinates:

$$\begin{gathered} x = \begin{pmatrix} r \\ 0 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \text{ and } x' = \begin{pmatrix} r'\cos\theta' \\ r'\sin\theta' \\ z' \end{pmatrix} \\ x - x' = \begin{pmatrix} r - r'\cos\theta' \\ -r'\sin\theta' \\ -z' \end{pmatrix} \text{ and } |x - x'|^2 = r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2 \end{gathered} \tag{9}$$

and reparameterize the density as $\rho(x') \to \rho(r', z')$.

Then the gravity field becomes

$$\begin{aligned} g(x) = g(r) &= \int_{\theta'}\int_{r'}\int_{z'} \frac{\rho(r', z')}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}} \begin{pmatrix} r - r'\cos\theta' \\ -r'\sin\theta' \\ -z' \end{pmatrix} \mathrm{d}z'\,r'\,\mathrm{d}r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \\ &= \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty}\int_{-\infty}^{0} \frac{\rho(r', z')}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}} \begin{pmatrix} r - r'\cos\theta' \\ -r'\sin\theta' \\ -z' \end{pmatrix} \mathrm{d}z'\,r'\,\mathrm{d}r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \\ &\quad \text{note that the y component is an odd function in } \theta' \\ &= \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty}\int_{-\infty}^{0} \frac{\rho(r', z')}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}} \begin{pmatrix} r - r'\cos\theta' \\ 0 \\ -z' \end{pmatrix} \mathrm{d}z'\,r'\,\mathrm{d}r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \end{aligned} \tag{10}$$

Then we are left with only radial and vertical components of the gravity field, as expected from an axially symmetric ρ

$$\begin{aligned} g_r(r) &= \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty}\int_{-\infty}^{0} \rho(r', z') \cdot \frac{r - r'\cos\theta'}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}}\,\mathrm{d}z'\,r'\,\mathrm{d}r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \\ g_z(r) &= \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty}\int_{-\infty}^{0} \rho(r', z') \cdot \frac{-z'}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}}\,\mathrm{d}z'\,r'\,\mathrm{d}r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \end{aligned} \tag{11}$$

Substituting the ASS parameterization for ρ

$$\begin{aligned} g_r(r) &= \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty}\int_{-b(r')}^{0} 1 \cdot \frac{r - r'\cos\theta'}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}}\,\mathrm{d}z'\,r'\,\mathrm{d}r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \\ g_z(r) &= \int_0^{2\pi}\int_0^{\infty}\int_{-b(r')}^{0} 1 \cdot \frac{-z'}{(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + z'^2)^{\frac{3}{2}}}\,\mathrm{d}z'\,r'\,\mathrm{d}r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \end{aligned} \tag{12}$$

As we are doing a numerical optimization of the gravity field, the derivative with respect to $b(r')$ is of interest. Applying the fundamental theorem of calculus, we get

$$
\begin{aligned}
\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}b(r')}[g_r(r)] &= \int_0^{2\pi} 0 - \frac{r - r'\cos\theta'}{\left(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + b(r')^2\right)^{\frac{3}{2}}}(-1)r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \\
&= \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{r - r'\cos\theta'}{\left(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + b(r')^2\right)^{\frac{3}{2}}} r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta'
\end{aligned} \tag{13}
$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
\frac{\mathrm{d}}{\mathrm{d}b(r')}[g_z(r)] &= \int_0^{2\pi} 0 - -\frac{-b(r')}{\left(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + b(r')^2\right)^{\frac{3}{2}}}(-1)r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta' \\
&= \int_0^{2\pi} \frac{b(r')}{\left(r^2 + r'^2 - 2rr'\cos\theta' + b(r')^2\right)^{\frac{3}{2}}} r'\,\mathrm{d}\theta'
\end{aligned} \tag{14}
$$

8.3. Rescaling to SI Units

Bibliography

[1] C. Hirt, S. Claessens, T. Fecher, M. Kuhn, R. Pail, and M. Rexer, “New ultrahigh-resolution picture of Earth's gravity field,” *Geophysical Research Letters*, vol. 40, no. 16, pp. 4279–4283, 2013, doi: https://doi.org/10.1002/grl.50838.